



CASE STUDY

Joliet Township District Raises Special Education Graduation Rate

Joliet Township High School District 204 turned to Hanover Research to improve outcomes, raising the Special Education graduation rate 5.5 points in two years.

Joliet Township High School District 204 (JTHS), a 9-12 secondary district in Joliet, Illinois, aims “to maximize every student’s potential to positively impact their community and thrive in a global society by providing an equitable, personalized, and rigorous education.”

As part of JTHS’ commitment to each student, especially students with disabilities and specialized support needs, the district partnered with Hanover Research (Hanover) to launch a series of research projects to measure the effectiveness of its special education programs and ultimately create an action plan for sustaining a more accessible and healthier school climate.

THE CHALLENGE: INVESTIGATE ACADEMIC AND BEHAVIORAL GAPS AMONG STUDENTS RECEIVING SPECIAL EDUCATION SERVICES

Similar to trends seen nationally, JTHS found consistent academic proficiency, attendance, and disciplinary gaps in its district data, particularly for students with special needs. District leadership wanted to gain a comprehensive view of its Special Education practices to understand how to reduce disparities and further their commitment to continuous improvement. Moreover, JTHS leadership aimed to forge an external partnership that could deliver an objective and thorough analysis.

JTHS partnered with Hanover to leverage research methodologies that could uncover unbiased, data-driven insights and maximize the district’s leadership in providing high-quality learning for all students.



THE CLIENT DISTRICT

Joliet Township High School District 204

LOCATION

Joliet, Illinois

THE CHALLENGE

Investigate the effectiveness of special education services

HANOVER SOLUTION

Quantitative Data Analysis,
Survey Research

“We wanted to improve our Special Education services to exceed state and federal compliance to ensure all our learners have the tools and support they need to succeed. The Hanover team understood our goals and used data and evidence to point us in the right direction toward achieving those goals.”

—Dianne McDonald,
Assistant Superintendent, Educational Services



53%

The percentage of students receiving Special Education services with at least one disciplinary incident compared to 45% of students enrolled in general education



71%

The percentage of students who think the district helps Special Education students achieve academically

THE SOLUTION: A QUANTITATIVE AND QUALITATIVE APPROACH TO IMPROVE STUDENT OUTCOMES

To uncover why some student groups were struggling more than others, Hanover developed a two-pronged methodology: a quantitative analysis of outcomes for students receiving Special Education services using district data and a broad-based perceptions survey of over 500 district students, educators, and caregivers.

The Hanover team selected this mixed-methods approach because a quantitative analysis could thoroughly measure program data to identify outcome gaps and trends, while the qualitative survey captured participants’ experiences and needs. Together, an analysis of these datasets ensured that the final recommendations addressed both organizational and human factors that affect student success

Accordingly, Hanover’s comprehensive analysis uncovered the following insights:

- Approximately 14% of JTHS students participate in Special Education services each year. Participation rates are highest among English learning students, students from low-income backgrounds, and Black students.
- Students receiving Special Education services are more likely to experience disciplinary incidents or chronic absenteeism than their peers. However, specialized support and care can help lessen incidents of chronic absenteeism or suspension.
- Educators and staff cite a need for more planning time and collaboration with colleagues, while parents desire more timely communication and greater involvement in school activities.

“Hanover provided the objective, third-party research and analysis we needed to answer why some of our students receiving specialized services had different rates of academic and behavioral outcomes, along with concrete ways to address those gaps. As a district, we simply would not have had the capacity to take on this work as comprehensively and diligently as Hanover did.”

—Dianne McDonald,
Assistant Superintendent, Educational Services

THE OUTCOME: DATA-INFORMED RECOMMENDATIONS TO EXCEED STATE MANDATES

Hanover’s analysis detailed not only community concerns and improvement areas but also provided insights from a quantitative perspective. Using these data sets together, Hanover partnered with JTHS to outline a path toward actionable and meaningful improvements.

As a result of the research findings, Hanover provided the following tailored recommendations to help Joliet Township High School District 204 excel in its future improvement initiatives for students receiving Special Education services:

- Identify and address drivers of student truancy among students receiving Special Education services.
- Enhance parent engagement by improving communication and increasing parent involvement in school activities, especially regarding English language services and behavioral support and updates.
- Further investigate disciplinary referral and outcome processes to ensure that referrals and outcomes are assigned equitably across student groups.
- Offer more professional development opportunities according to staff and educator needs and interests, such as more comprehensive education regarding specific disabilities, chronic illnesses, and other specialized support needs.

Just two years after implementing Hanover’s recommendations, the graduation rate for students receiving Special Education services rose by an average of 5.5 percentage points.

Going forward, JTHS’ proactive, data-driven approach will ensure it remains a leader in providing high-quality education for all students, while providing the necessary supports and practices to help students with disabilities thrive.



14%

The percentage of students who use Special Education services



36%

The percentage of Special Education instructional staff that would like to receive training on specific disabilities